

D658

Planning Instructional Strategies for Meaningful Learning

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A fifth-grade team is planning a new unit on ecosystems. One teacher found a popular terrarium-building kit that students loved last spring, and the school just bought new science tables. Following backward design, what should the team do first?

- A. Design the unit test before looking at any standards.
- B. Write the daily lesson activities, then build a test from them.
- C. Identify the standards and the understandings students should reach by the end of the unit.
- D. Plan the terrarium activity, since students already enjoy it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher has written unit goals and a performance task that would show mastery. Under backward design, what is the next planning step?

- A. Give the performance task right away as a pretest and stop planning.
- B. Plan the learning experiences and instruction that prepare students for the task.
- C. Pick the standards to cover.
- D. Rewrite the goals so they fit the task.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A new teacher in a busy middle school is drafting an objective for a lesson on fractions. The mentor, who has taught for twenty years, asks for one that can be observed and measured. Which objective is strongest?

- A. Students will compare two fractions with unlike denominators and explain which is greater using a model.
- B. Students will understand fractions with unlike denominators.
- C. The teacher will demonstrate comparing fractions on the board.
- D. Students will enjoy a fraction game with a partner.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A standard asks students to analyze how an author's word choice shapes tone. The teacher's class period is 50 minutes and the unit uses a well-reviewed anthology. Which assessment is best aligned to the standard?

- A. A matching quiz pairing vocabulary words with definitions.
- B. Students list every adjective in the passage.
- C. Students pick a passage, cite specific words, and explain how those words create the tone.
- D. Any assessment from the anthology's test bank, since it is well reviewed.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher's end-of-unit task asks students only to recall the dates of three events. Which standard would this task be well aligned to?

- A. Any history standard, since dates are part of all history.
- B. Evaluate the causes of a historical event.
- C. Identify key dates and events in a historical period.
- D. Compare two perspectives on a historical event.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A teacher shows students once how to write a topic sentence, then assigns a paragraph to write alone. The classroom has a new document camera, and the lesson follows an assembly schedule. Most paragraphs lack a clear topic sentence. What step was most likely skipped?

- A. A longer demonstration using the document camera.
- B. An independent practice worksheet before the paragraph.
- C. A unit test to measure mastery.
- D. Guided practice, where students try it with teacher feedback before working alone.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

Midway through a lesson on area, a teacher wants to know whether the whole class can find the area of a rectangle. The class of 28 is seated in table groups, and the principal is observing. Which check gives the best information?

- A. Ask “Does everyone understand?” and watch for nods.
- B. Call on the two students who raised their hands.
- C. Wait until the unit test to see who learned it.
- D. Every student solves one problem on a mini whiteboard and holds it up.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

After an exit ticket, a teacher sees that 18 of 24 students solved the problem correctly and the 6 who missed it all made the same error. What is the best next step?

- A. Move on with everyone, since 75% is passing.
- B. Reteach the whole lesson to all 24 students.
- C. Give the 6 students a lower grade and continue.
- D. Move on with the class and pull the 6 students for a short reteach on that error.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

In a fourth-grade class reading about the water cycle, some students read well above grade level and others read below it. The school uses a four-day schedule this week. Which plan best differentiates while keeping the same goal?

- A. Offer water-cycle texts at different reading levels, with all students explaining the same cycle stages.
- B. Shorten the lesson for everyone because of the schedule.
- C. Students below level color a water-cycle picture while others write explanations.
- D. Give the advanced readers extra worksheets of the same kind.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Students in one class all learn the same content in the same way, but they may show mastery with a written report, a labeled poster, or a recorded talk. What is being differentiated?

- A.** Product
- B.** The learning goal
- C.** Process
- D.** Content

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A teacher is planning a science lesson for a diverse class. Last year's class was quieter, and the room gets bright afternoon sun. Which planning choice best reflects Universal Design for Learning?

- A.** Close the blinds and use the same plan as last year.
- B.** Present the concept through a demonstration, a diagram, and a short text, and let students show learning in more than one way.
- C.** Use one lecture format because it is the most efficient.
- D.** Wait to see which students struggle, then add accommodations for them.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A teacher wants students to compare how two cities' temperatures change over a year. The district recently gave every class a set of tablets, and a colleague suggests a popular quiz game app. Which technology choice best serves the objective?

- A.** A typing program so students practice keyboarding.
- B.** A spreadsheet where students graph both cities' monthly temperatures and describe the differences.
- C.** The quiz game app, because students find it engaging.
- D.** Any app on the tablets, since technology always increases learning.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A fifth-grade team is planning a new unit on ecosystems. ~~One teacher found a popular terrarium building kit that students loved last spring, and the school just bought new science tables.~~ Following backward design, what should the team do first?

Target word: first step of backward design **Decides:** Backward design begins with the desired results.

A	Dropped element	Skips stage one; evidence must be aligned to goals that are defined first.
B	Inverted operation	That is forward planning; assessment evidence is planned before activities.
C	Correct	Stage one of backward design is defining the desired results.
D	Camouflage	Reacts to the kit detail; activities come last in backward design.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

A teacher has written unit goals and a performance task that would show mastery. Under backward design, what is the next planning step?

Target word: which step follows evidence **Decides:** Stage three is the learning plan.

A	Adjacent category	Pre-assessment can inform the plan but does not replace planning instruction.
B	Correct	After results and evidence comes the learning plan.
C	Dropped element	Standards were already set in stage one.
D	Inverted operation	Goals drive the evidence, not the other way around.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A new teacher ~~in a busy middle school~~ is drafting an objective for a lesson on fractions. The mentor, ~~who has taught for twenty years,~~ asks for one that can be observed and measured. Which objective is strongest?

Target word: measurable objective **Decides:** An observable student action with a condition or criterion.

A	Correct	Compare and explain are observable actions tied to the content.
B	Confusion set	Understand is an internal state that cannot be directly observed.
C	Adjacent category	Describes teacher activity, not what students will be able to do.
D	Camouflage	Names an activity and a feeling, not a measurable learning outcome.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A standard asks students to analyze how an author's word choice shapes tone. ~~The teacher's class period is 50 minutes and the unit uses a well-reviewed anthology.~~ Which assessment is best aligned to the standard?

Target word: assessment matching the standard's cognitive demand **Decides:** The verb is analyze.

A	Adjacent category	Tests recall of meanings, a lower level than analysis.
B	Dropped element	Identifies words but drops the link to tone.
C	Correct	Requires analysis of word choice and its effect, matching the standard.
D	Absolute language	Quality of the book does not guarantee alignment to this standard.

5. Answer C Concept 3 · transfer

A teacher's end-of-unit task asks students only to recall the dates of three events. Which standard would this task be well aligned to?

Target word: reverse: find the standard that matches a recall task **Decides:** A recall task aligns to a recall-level standard.

A	Absolute language	Alignment depends on the thinking demanded, not just the topic.
B	Inverted operation	Evaluate is far above what a recall task measures.
C	Correct	Identify/recall matches the demand of the task.
D	Adjacent category	Comparison requires analysis the task never asks for.

6. Answer D Concept 4

A teacher shows students once how to write a topic sentence, then assigns a paragraph to write alone. ~~The classroom has a new document camera, and the lesson follows an assembly schedule.~~ Most paragraphs lack a clear topic sentence. What step was most likely skipped?

Target word: missing phase of gradual release **Decides:** Demonstration went straight to independent work.

A	Camouflage	Focuses on the equipment; more modeling alone does not replace guided practice.
B	Inverted operation	Adds more you do before students were supported.
C	Adjacent category	Summative testing does not build the skill students lacked.
D	Correct	The we do phase catches errors before independent practice.

7. Answer D Concept 5

Midway through a lesson on area, a teacher wants to know whether the whole class can find the area of a rectangle. ~~The class of 28 is seated in table groups, and the principal is observing.~~ Which check gives the best information?

Target word: check for understanding from all students **Decides:** Needs evidence from every student, mid-lesson.

A	Confusion set	Self-report and silence are not evidence of understanding.
B	Dropped element	Samples only volunteers, not the whole class.
C	Adjacent category	A summative test comes too late to adjust today's lesson.
D	Correct	An all-response check shows who has it right now.

8. Answer D Concept 5 · transfer

After an exit ticket, a teacher sees that 18 of 24 students solved the problem correctly and the 6 who missed it all made the same error. What is the best next step?

Target word: reverse: act on check results **Decides:** Most got it; a small group shares one error.

A	Dropped element	Drops the 6 students the check identified.
B	Inverted operation	Ignores that 75% already showed mastery.
C	Adjacent category	Grading is not adjusting instruction.
D	Correct	The data point to targeted small-group reteaching, not whole-class.

9. Answer A Concept 6

In a fourth-grade class reading about the water cycle, some students read well above grade level and others read below it. ~~The school uses a four-day schedule this week.~~ Which plan best differentiates while keeping the same goal?

Target word: differentiation that keeps the goal **Decides:** Same standard, varied access.

A	Correct	Varies content access while holding the learning goal constant.
B	Camouflage	Reacts to the schedule, not to learner differences.
C	Inverted operation	Lowers the goal instead of supporting access to it.
D	Adjacent category	More of the same is not differentiation.

10. Answer A Concept 6 · transfer

Students in one class all learn the same content in the same way, but they may show mastery with a written report, a labeled poster, or a recorded talk. What is being differentiated?

Target word: name the differentiated element **Decides:** The way students show learning varies.

A	Correct	Product is how students demonstrate learning.
B	Adjacent category	Differentiation keeps the goal the same.
C	Confusion set	Process is how students make sense of ideas; it is the same here.
D	Confusion set	Content is what students learn or access; it is the same here.

11. Answer B Concept 7

A teacher is planning a science lesson for a diverse class. ~~Last year's class was quieter, and the room gets bright afternoon sun.~~ Which planning choice best reflects Universal Design for Learning?

Target word: UDL at the planning stage **Decides:** Flexible options built in for all learners.

A	Camouflage	Reacts to the room and last year's class, not to learner variability.
B	Correct	Multiple means of representation and expression, planned for everyone.
C	Dropped element	Removes the flexibility that defines UDL.
D	Inverted operation	Retrofitting after failure is the opposite of designing up front.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A teacher wants students to compare how two cities' temperatures change over a year. ~~The district recently gave every class a set of tablets, and a colleague suggests a popular quiz game app.~~ Which technology choice best serves the objective?

Target word: tool matched to the objective **Decides:** The objective is comparing data over time.

A	Adjacent category	A real skill, but not this lesson's objective.
B	Correct	Graphing the data directly supports comparison.
C	Camouflage	Engagement alone does not serve the comparison goal.
D	Absolute language	Technology helps only when it fits the goal.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	6	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	10	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	3	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	4	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Backward design	Start from the learning goal, then decide the evidence of learning, then plan the activities.	Choosing a fun activity first and fitting a standard to it afterward.	A planning sequence where the question is what comes first.
2	Measurable objectives	A strong objective names an observable student action tied to the standard (identify, compare, explain), not an internal state.	Writing objectives with verbs like understand, appreciate, or learn about.	Several objective statements to compare for quality.
3	Alignment of cognitive demand	The task and the assessment must demand the same level of thinking the standard asks for.	Assessing an analyze-level standard with a recall quiz.	The standard's verb and the task's verb do not match.
4	Explicit instruction and gradual release	Model (I do), guide with feedback (we do), then release to independent practice (you do) once students show success.	Jumping from a short demonstration straight to independent work.	Many students fail independent practice right after a demonstration.
5	Checks for understanding drive adjustment	Frequent in-lesson checks from all students tell the teacher whether to reteach, regroup, or move on.	Asking "Any questions?" or calling only on volunteers and treating silence as understanding.	The teacher needs to know, mid-lesson, whether the whole class got it.
6	Differentiation of content, process, product	Keep the learning goal the same and vary how students access it, work with it, or show it.	Lowering the goal for some students or simply giving more of the same work to fast finishers.	Students with different readiness working toward one standard.
7	Universal Design for Learning	Plan flexible options for engagement, representation, and action/expression up front so fewer barriers exist for everyone.	Treating UDL as retrofitting accommodations for one student after the lesson fails.	Options built into the plan for all learners before instruction.
8	Technology serves the goal	Choose a tool because it helps reach the learning objective, not because it is new or engaging.	Assuming any use of devices increases learning.	A choice among tools, one of which matches the objective's thinking.

Course scope (public description): Planning Instructional Strategies for Meaningful Learning is a dynamic course designed for educators seeking to deepen their understanding of instructional planning and the execution of educational strategies that foster meaningful learning experiences. This course provides candidates with the knowledge and skills necessary to create engaging and standards-aligned lessons that meet the needs of all students. This course also covers a range of high-leverage instructional practices to increase student learning, engagement, and achievement. Participants will learn to utilize assessments to inform instruction, adapt teaching to accommodate all students, and incorporate technology to enhance learning.